

“All the News
That’s Fit to Print”

The New York Times

THE WEATHER
Today, high clouds, humid, high 85. Tonight, partly cloudy, humid, winds light and variable, low 72. Tomorrow, mostly cloudy, breezy, humid, high 82. Weather map, Page A16.

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Prices in Canada may be higher

\$4.00

‘Botched’ Job, Not Sabotage, Damaged Pool

Charges to Be Dropped Against Ex-Olympian

By MADALEINE RUBIN and
DAVID A. FAHRENTHOLD

Federal prosecutors have moved to drop charges against a former Olympic canoeist who was accused of vandalizing the Lincoln Memorial Reflecting Pool, acknowledging that a contractor hired by the Trump administration had “botched” its renovation.

In a motion filed in District of Columbia Superior Court on Friday, the U.S. attorney in Washington, Jeanine Pirro, said that her office had received documents showing the damage to the pool “was the result of a flawed installation by the contractor, Atlantic Industrial Coatings, and the rush to complete the project prior to events associated with the America250 celebration” on July 4.

“Given all of this newly discovered information,” she wrote, “it is difficult to attribute the widespread damage to the Reflecting Pool to vandalism, let alone to establish that fact beyond a reasonable doubt.”

The canoeist, David Hearn, 67, was one of seven people facing charges in connection with what President Trump had claimed, without evidence, were efforts to sabotage his administration’s renovation of the pool.

Mr. Hearn was the only person known to be facing a felony charge, rather than a misdemeanor. It was unclear if vandalism-related charges against other defendants were also being dismissed.

Mr. Hearn pleaded not guilty this month to a charge of destruction of property. His trial had been scheduled to begin on Sept. 28.

Mr. Hearn was arrested in June after the police claimed he had peeled blue-tinted waterproofing off the pool floor. The coating had begun to peel several days before, according to internal government documents.

His lawyers said that his actions were not criminal conduct. They had filed a motion to dismiss the case asserting that the “government has failed to preserve the key physical evidence in this case: the Lincoln Memorial Reflecting Pool, including the section of its liner that Mr. Hearn is charged with damaging.”

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ANTONIO SEMPERE/ASSOCIATED PRESS

By Friday afternoon, the Spanish authorities said the majority of the migrants who had flooded into Ceuta had returned to Morocco.

Rescuers Show Signs of Harm To the Brain but Aren’t Helped

By DAVE PHILIPPS

CULLOWHEE, N.C. — Brett Bonner saved hundreds of lives during 21 years on rescue boats in the Coast Guard. When he died, his teenage daughter Kayleigh wondered why he could not save his own.

He was a big, gregarious man who seemed able to handle anything. But as Kayleigh grew up, she watched him slowly fall apart. First came headaches, and then sleeplessness. His memory frayed, and his moods turned raw.

When he retired from the Coast Guard at age 40 in 2022, things grew worse. He would rant and scream. One afternoon, he dropped her grandfather with one punch. In the months after, he started setting things on fire.

On a winter evening in 2025, with a pile of Coast Guard files burning on the living room floor, he walked out the front door and

Coast Guard Has Not Studied the Effects of Heavy Waves

shot himself dead.

Kayleigh, her mother, her younger sister and her two little brothers all saw it happen.

He left no note. He offered no explanation. His coming apart left his family so perplexed about how to sum up his life that they buried him without a headstone.

Kayleigh, who is now 18, was devastated. But after the funeral, she started to wonder.

Her father was a surferman — an elite rescuer whose job was to drive lifeboats through crashing waves as high as 25 feet. Maybe all those years crashing into waves had left her father with an unseen

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Rush of Migrants Into Territory Of Spain Ignites a Backlash

This article is by Jason Horowitz,
Carlos Barragán and Thomas Fuller.

CEUTA, Spain — Tens of thousands of migrants streamed into a Spanish territory at the tip of North Africa, igniting a refugee crisis and a political firestorm in Europe on Friday that pitted Spain’s liberal pro-immigration government against right-wing critics across the continent.

Pedro Sánchez, Spain’s prime minister, rushed on Friday to Ceuta, the autonomous Spanish enclave contiguous with Morocco, and said 400 additional security forces had been sent to the border. By Friday afternoon, the Spanish authorities said 48,300 people — the majority of the estimated 50,000 or 60,000 migrants who had flooded into Ceuta since Thursday — had returned to Morocco.

Three dozen migrants died at-

Exodus From Morocco Draws Ire of the Right Across Europe

tempting the journey into the Spanish territory, the authorities said. Migrants described swimming past the bodies of the dead.

Questions lingered about what would happen to the many thousands who remained in Ceuta and whether some would make it to the European mainland a dozen miles across the Strait of Gibraltar.

“I don’t want to live in Morocco, I want to live in Europe,” said Zakaria Lahmer, 23, a migrant who spoke through what he described as pangs of hunger. But he said he was determined to reach Spain. “I want a job, I want happiness.”

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MAGA’s Media Machine Is Starting to Splinter

By STUART A. THOMPSON

Benny Johnson, a right-wing podcaster, was racking up tens of millions of views on YouTube during Donald J. Trump’s 2024 reelection campaign, posting about divisive cultural issues and criticizing Democrats.

Things have changed. Views for Mr. Johnson’s YouTube channel are down by millions from the heights of 2024. The surge of attention he received on X has slowed to a trickle. His loyalty to Mr. Trump has become unappealing to some Republicans who are frustrated with the rising cost of living and the president’s decision to start a war with Iran.

Other high-profile right-wing influencers are contending with similar shifts of fortune. Dan Bongino, a podcaster and a former deputy director of the F.B.I., has seen his livestream views shrink by about half from their peak in 2024. Megyn Kelly, a former Fox News host, has found moments of explosive growth, yet that attention has been hard to sustain.

The shifts add to a growing body of evidence that suggests the audience for pro-Trump content has fallen from its heights and, for some creators, has reached new lows. Views are

dropping for many of Mr. Trump’s greatest allies, while some figures on the right who have taken to criticizing Mr. Trump are showing uneven gains.

The shifts threaten to complicate messaging this year for Re-

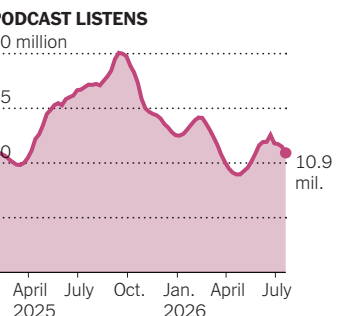
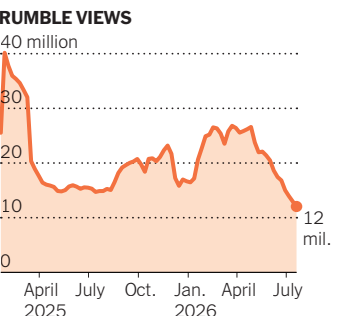
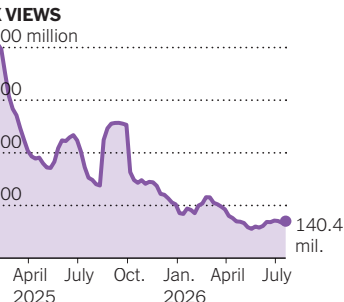
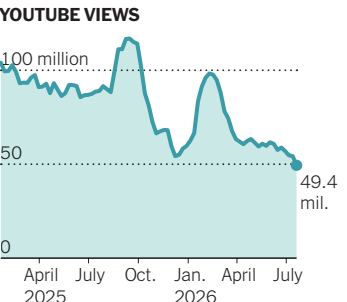
publican candidates, who have for years relied on a united front of content creators to rile up Republicans and guide them to the polls each election cycle.

“The vote is in November, but

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Losing an Audience

Total views per week for 12 right-wing influencers



Note: Weekly views, seven-week moving average. Sources: YouTube, TweetBinder by Audiense (X data), Rumble, Podchaser (podcast listens). STUART A. THOMPSON/THE NEW YORK TIMES

In Homeland of Tacos, Chipotle Tries to Fit In

By JAMES WAGNER

MONTERREY, Mexico — The line of nearly 200 customers for the restaurant’s recent grand opening stretched on both sides of the main entrance, with some patrons arriving four hours early despite the heat. Many had been anticipating this day for months.

When the workers pressed a button meant to look like a burrito wrapped in aluminum foil, the facade of the restaurant was unveiled and confetti shot into the air.

In the homeland of tacos, burritos and quesadillas, a new competitor has entered the market: Chipotle, the Mexican-inspired fast casual chain that is ubiquitous in the United States.

“What pride that the first one in Mexico and in Latin America is here,” said Gaby Rodríguez, 44, a lawyer from Monterrey who was the first person in line, in an affluent suburb of that city. The first 100 customers got a free Chipotle tote bag, T-shirt and hat.

But after another American chain, Taco Bell, failed twice south of the border, can Chipotle successfully sell its version of Mexican food to Mexicans in Mexico?

Mexicans take enormous pride in their cuisine, which is widely recognized as one of the world’s

Mexico’s Spicy Market Could Be an Issue

best. It has reached all over the globe thanks, in large part, to Mexican migration.

As it traveled, Mexican food evolved to fit the available local ingredients and tastes. Chipotle, named for a smoked and dried jalapeño pepper, is a prime example of this adaptation, inspired by San

Francisco’s taco and burrito shops in the early 1990s. It has since grown into a massive chain with over 4,000 locations, primarily in the United States.

Many of Chipotle’s first customers in Mexico were people nostalgic to eat it again after having visited or lived in the United States. One couple met through Chipotle in the United States years ago before moving to Mexico. A good chunk of customers were in their 20s and 30s, wearing

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LUIS ANTONIO ROJAS FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

Families eating last month at Chipotle in San Pedro in Monterrey, the first outlet the American chain has opened in Mexico.

BUSINESS B1-6

Worry on Tech’s A.I. Spending

As money is poured into artificial intelligence, concerns grow over whether the outlays are justified. PAGE B1

China Luring Factories Back

For some U.S. brands seeking a location for their factories, the economic logic is once again pointing to Beijing. PAGE B1



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Records Requests Surge

A Times analysis of 16 years of available federal data shows federal agencies lag in processing requests for government records. PAGE A10

A Vow of No Party Flip

With a focus on the prospect of party-switchers upending the Senate equilibrium, the most attention is on Democratic Senator John Fetterman. PAGE A11

Loyalty to Trump a Risk

Todd Blanche’s approach has collided with the jury-of-two reality in the Senate that has, so far, kept him from confirmation as attorney general. PAGE A14

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David González has suddenly become the host of Havana’s hottest celebrations amid its energy crisis. Can he turn them into a movement? PAGE A4

Tracking a German Extremist

The assailant was jailed after trying to join ISIS but freed weeks before attacking a gay Pride event in Berlin. PAGE A6

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Trading Skyline for Mountains

Since 2013, the Giants have trained in East Rutherford, N.J. This year, they are at a resort in West Virginia. PAGE B7

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The Angst Behind the Mask

The latest “Spider-Man” movie is meant to return to Peter Parker’s roots as a lonely, struggling young man. PAGE C5

America Hardly Knows Her

The Statue of Liberty is much stranger as an object than an icon. A critic delves into its unusual history. PAGE C1



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Suggestions for Serenity

A visit to some of the best botanical gardens in U.S. cities, including Phoenix, Miami and St. Louis. PAGE C10

36 Hours on the Oregon Coast

For this stretch of seashore, pack your coziest flannel and plan for a moody sky and weather-beaten cliffs. PAGE C11

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Lydia Polgreen

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